

Breaking the shell

The exercise is called 'breaking the shell', the minimum for it is about an hour (timings given below), although it works much better if given up to two hours.

[5 mins]

The set-up is to focus everyone on a vision - something clear and simple, quickly covered.

[15 mins]

Then the question is 'what barriers stand in the way of achieving this'? The idea then is to get as many barriers out as possible, one per post-it note. I usually get everyone to spend a couple of minutes producing as many as possible, then read them out and put them all on a flip-chart; hearing everyone else's tends to get people producing many more.

[10 mins]

At this stage it's a good idea to have a coffee break so people are just focusing on all the problems and issues - a deliberate down-point.

[5 mins]

The next step is to introduce the categorisation approach. Barriers are categorised into four groups:

Brick walls - insurmountable obstacles we just have to live with!

Paper walls - look like real walls until tested, but are easily overcome, even by individuals

Partition walls - hard for individuals, but management or a project effort can overcome

Mindset issues - like collective paper walls, common assumptions that are not easily overcome

[10 mins]

Then everyone has to place their post-its on a different chart according to which type of barrier they are, and in the process group similar barriers together

[15 mins]

Finally, there is a group discussion to agree the categorisation and consider the issues.

The whole purpose of the exercise is to get all the concerns and obstacles out on the table, then change the way people are thinking about the obstacles. The categorisation changes our psychological approach - brick walls just aren't worth worrying about anyway, paper walls we should just get over, and the others can actually be worked on.

This naturally leads on to an action planning session - every individual commits to overcome their 'paper walls', and key actions to address the partition walls and mindset issues are discussed and agreed. The whole set could potentially be done in an hour and a half, if squeezed.

Made available under a Creative Commons licence from RedQuadrant – attribution required.

Please feed back results to ben.taylor@redquadrant.com